



CXE-01 | FREE PREVIEW

Engineering the Customer Experience

FREE PREVIEW EDITION • Theory, practice and certification for contact-service teams

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PARTICIPANT MANUAL (PREVIEW) • Agent Track + Leader Track

Organization / Department: _____

Participant name: _____

Employee ID / Team: _____

Facilitator: _____

Dates: _____

This is a free preview

This **free preview** shows the structure and about 30% of the Customer Experience Engineering Participant Manual. The full program includes every skill, tool, script, updated 2024-2026 data, the leader track, and four certification assessments (theory + role plays + live interactions).

Book a free 30-minute consultation to see how it fits your team: **Juan Carlos Munguia**, Continuous Improvement Consulting

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How to use this manual

This manual is the core reading and workbook for the **Customer Experience Engineering (CXE)** internal certification. It is written for a contact-service operation of any size: an in-house customer service department, a shared-service center, or an outsourced (BPO) program. The organization used in examples, **ACME Customer Care Center**, is fictitious. Replace it with your own organization, teams and leaders wherever you see blank fields.

Two tracks, one standard

	Level 1: CXE Practitioner (Agent track)	Level 2: CXE Leader (Leader track)
Who	Frontline agents / customer service specialists (CSS) in voice, chat, email, messaging, social and back office	Team leaders, supervisors, QA analysts, trainers, workforce and operations managers
Your "customer"	The external customer	Your agents (internal customers) and, through them, the external customer
Modules	1 to 5 and 7	1 to 7 (all), with Module 6 as the core of the leader track
Theoretical exam	Assessment A, pass mark 80%	Assessment B, pass mark 85%
Practical exam	Assessment C: role plays + live interactions, 85% and zero critical errors	Assessment D: role plays with agents + live coaching and huddle, 85% and zero critical errors
Re-verification	Annual (aligned with COPC CX Standard R8.0, Item 3.3)	Annual, plus quarterly calibration



Icons and boxes you will see

Box	Meaning
Blue box	Key idea or learning objectives
Orange header	Activity: individual, pairs or group practice
Green box	Updated 2024 to 2026 evidence with its source
Purple box	Leader lens: how a leader applies the same skill with agents
Red box	Watch out: common mistakes and critical errors

Program overview and agenda

The program has seven modules. The agent track runs in two days (about 14 hours). The leader track adds a third day for Module 6 and the leader practical assessment. Times are guides; facilitators can adapt them.

Day	Block	Module / content	Track
1	08:30-10:30	Module 1: Introduction to Customer Experience Engineering	All
1	10:45-13:00	Module 2: What I Hear (Skill 1 Active Listening, Skill 2 Purposeful Small Talk)	All
1	14:00-17:30	Module 3: How I Respond (Skill 3 Positive Language, Skill 4 Advocacy, Skill 5 Alternative Positioning)	All
2	08:30-11:00	Module 4: Develop and Maintain Self-Awareness (Skills 6 and 7)	All
2	11:15-13:00	Module 5: Experience Engineering in the AI era (hybrid journeys, digital channels)	All
2	14:00-16:00	Module 7: Topic facilitation activity, summary, first three steps	All
2	16:15-17:30	Assessment A (agents) / Assessment B (leaders): theoretical	All
3	08:30-13:00	Module 6: Leading by Example (the leader track)	Leaders
3	14:00-17:30	Assessment D Part 1 (leader role plays)	Leaders
+2 to 4 wks	On the floor	Assessment C Part 2 (agents) and D Part 2 (leaders): live observations	All

Meet ACME Customer Care Center (fictitious)

Every example in this manual uses the same fictitious operation, so you can follow one story from start to finish.

Item	ACME Customer Care Center	Your organization
Lines of business	Telecom and home internet, retail banking cards, e-commerce orders, event tickets, healthcare appointment scheduling	_____
Channels	Voice, chat, email, WhatsApp-style messaging, AI virtual assistant with human handoff	_____
Size	240 agents, 16 team leaders, 4 operations managers, 8 QA analysts, 3 trainers	_____
Key metrics	CSAT and DSAT, Customer Effort Score (CES), FCR, repeat contacts, transfers, AHT, critical error accuracy, attrition, agent eNPS	_____
People in the stories	Agents: Luis, Ana, Kenji, Fatima. Team leader: Dana. Ops manager: Marco. QA analyst: Priya	_____

1

Introduction to Customer Experience Engineering

Why reducing customer effort is the goal, and why being nice is not enough

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain why experience engineering is a critical frontline skill in 2026
- Describe the two components of customer effort and who controls each
- Distinguish traditional soft skills from experience engineering
- Name the seven skills of the framework and how they benefit you and your scorecard

1.1 An effective and emerging frontline skill

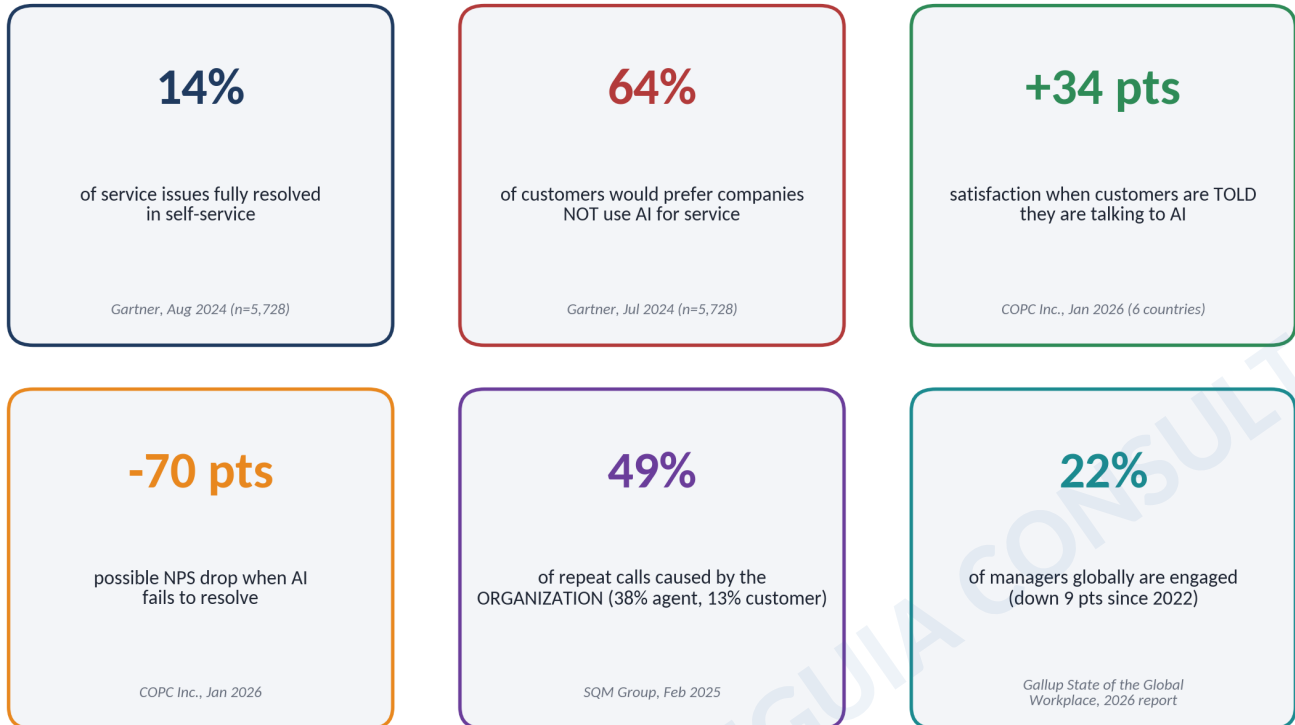
As service organizations work to improve the customer experience and earn loyalty, the skills that matter most are the ones aimed directly at that goal. **Customer Experience Engineering** is a strategy to **actively guide interactions** and **reduce customer effort**. With it you will learn to:

Keep control	Anticipate	Show you are on their side	Own your work
Guide each conversation with purpose instead of reacting to it	Get ahead of the customer's needs and of the next issue before it happens	Demonstrate a clear willingness to help, every time	Focus on what you can control and gain autonomy over how you handle each contact

1.2 Why it matters more than ever

Organizations that want to grow must **keep** the customers they already have, and the most reliable way to do that is to engineer better experiences. Three trends make this urgent in 2024 to 2026:

- **Simple issues are moving to self-service and AI, so humans get the hard ones.** Only 14% of service issues are fully resolved in self-service, and even among very simple issues only 36% are (Gartner, Aug 2024). When a customer reaches you, they have often already tried and failed, so their effort and emotion are higher.
- **Customers still want a human who helps.** 64% of customers would prefer companies not use AI for service, and 53% would consider switching to a competitor over it; the number one concern is difficulty reaching a person (Gartner, Jul 2024).
- **Leaders are redesigning, not removing, the human role.** 91% of service leaders feel pressure to implement AI in 2026, yet only 20% report AI-driven headcount reductions, and 84% plan to add new skills to agent roles (Gartner, Dec 2025 and Feb 2026).

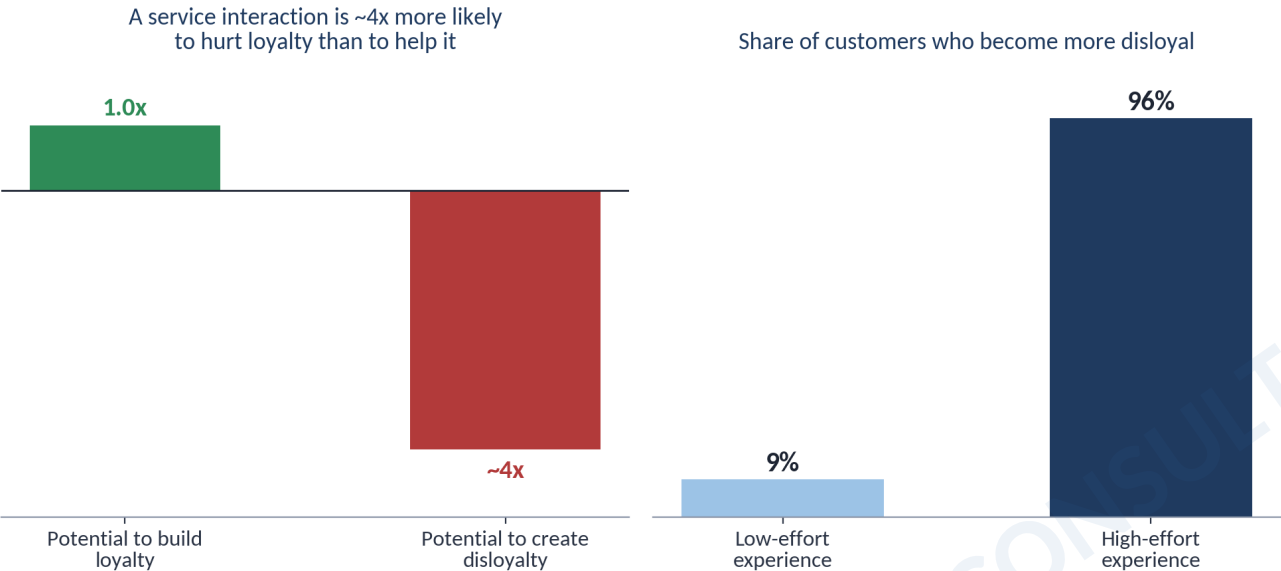


Updated evidence (2024-2026)

The human interaction is now the moment of truth for the most complex, most emotional problems. That is exactly where experience engineering has the highest return. Sources and verification links are in the Evidence and Sources Pack (document CXE-07).

1.3 Reducing customer effort: a goal with great value

Research by CEB (now part of Gartner) with more than 54,000 customers found that a service interaction is roughly **four times more likely to make a customer disloyal than loyal**. Your biggest opportunity is not to delight, but to **avoid creating disloyalty**, and the lever is effort: 96% of customers who had a high-effort experience became more disloyal, versus 9% after a low-effort one.



Source: CEB (now Gartner) Customer Loyalty Survey, n = 54,166; reported in Dixon, Toman & DeLisi, The Effortless Experience (2013). Still cited by Gartner as the effort-loyalty baseline.

Is this still true? (2026 check)

Yes. Newer studies point the same way. Qualtrics XM Institute (Q3 2025, 20,000+ consumers, 14 countries) estimates US\$3 trillion in global sales at risk from bad experiences in 2026; 47% of bad experiences lead customers to cut spending, and **Mexico has the highest share of spending at risk (8%)** of the countries studied. SQM Group (Feb 2025) finds that every 1-point gain in first call resolution raises interaction NPS by 1.4 points.

ACTIVITY Effort in my own life		
Purpose	Time	Materials
Connect effort to loyalty from your own experience as a customer	7 min	Pen, this page

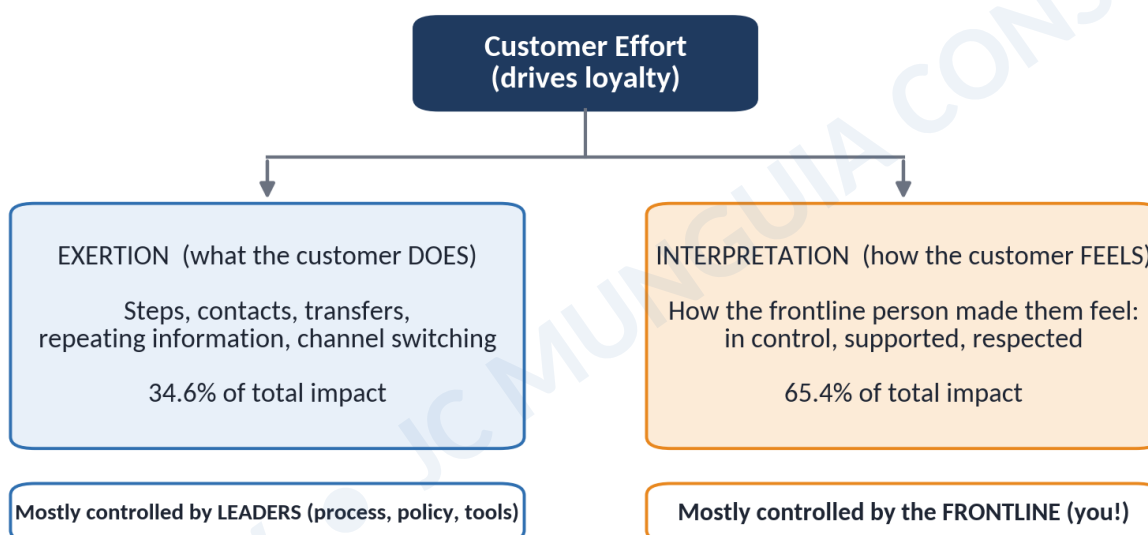
1. Write two sentences about a time a company made you work too hard as a customer (a bank, airline, phone company, government office).
2. Write how your own team or organization might unintentionally make customers work harder than necessary.
3. Share one example with the person next to you. Did the effort change what you did next as a customer?

My high-effort experience as a customer:

How we may unintentionally create effort for our customers:

1.4 What "effort" really means

Customer effort has two parts. **Exertion** is what the customer has to *do*: steps, contacts, transfers, repeating information, switching channels. **Interpretation** is how the customer *feels* about it: whether the frontline person made them feel supported and in control. In CEB's regression analysis (n = 4,589), interpretation carried **65.4%** of the impact on effort and exertion **34.6%**.



Examples of EXERTION (mostly controlled by leaders and process)	Examples of INTERPRETATION (mostly controlled by you)
• Number of contacts to solve one issue • Number of transfers • Repeating information already given (to the bot, to the IVR, to the last agent) • Being forced to switch channels ("please send us an email") • _____	• Flexibility shown by the frontline person • A visible willingness to help • Feeling that someone has taken control of the situation • Hearing what CAN be done, not only what cannot • _____

Leader lens

Exertion is 34.6% of the impact and it is largely designed by leaders: policies, IVR menus, tools, knowledge articles, transfer rules. The SQM 2025 benchmark finds the organization, not the agent, causes 49% of repeat calls. Leaders who only coach agents miss half the problem. See Module 6.

1.5 It goes beyond being nice

In the same CEB research, several classic soft skills showed **no measurable effect** on reducing effort, and two had only a marginal effect. Customers expect courtesy; it does not, by itself, reduce the work they must do or change how they interpret it.

NO measurable effect on effort	MARGINAL effect (< 5%)
• Showed concern • Was non-scripted • Understood the customer • Listened well	• Communicated clearly • Demonstrated confidence <i>Being nice is the entry ticket, not the differentiator.</i>

Discussion: Why do you think being nice is not enough? Where have you seen a very polite agent still leave you with all the work?

1.6 Traditional soft skills vs. experience engineering

Traditional soft skills	Customer Experience Engineering
Traditional soft skills are often taught in a top-down manner, focusing on specific behaviors and scripts. They are often seen as a means to achieve a specific goal, such as reducing customer effort or increasing satisfaction. However, these skills are often taught in a way that is not context-specific, leading to a lack of understanding of the customer's needs and expectations. Traditional soft skills are often taught in a way that is not context-specific, leading to a lack of understanding of the customer's needs and expectations. They are often seen as a means to achieve a specific goal, such as reducing customer effort or increasing satisfaction.	Customer Experience Engineering is a more holistic approach to customer service. It focuses on understanding the customer's journey and the underlying reasons for their behavior. It is a more context-specific approach, taking into account the customer's needs and expectations at each stage of the journey. Customer Experience Engineering is a more holistic approach to customer service. It focuses on understanding the customer's journey and the underlying reasons for their behavior. It is a more context-specific approach, taking into account the customer's needs and expectations at each stage of the journey.

Relationship focus	Outcome focus (experience engineering)
Relationship focus: The relationship between the customer and the company is the primary focus. This is often achieved through personalized service, loyalty programs, and direct communication channels.	Outcome focus (experience engineering): The focus is on the specific outcomes or experiences that the customer has with the company. This involves designing the customer journey to be seamless, engaging, and memorable.



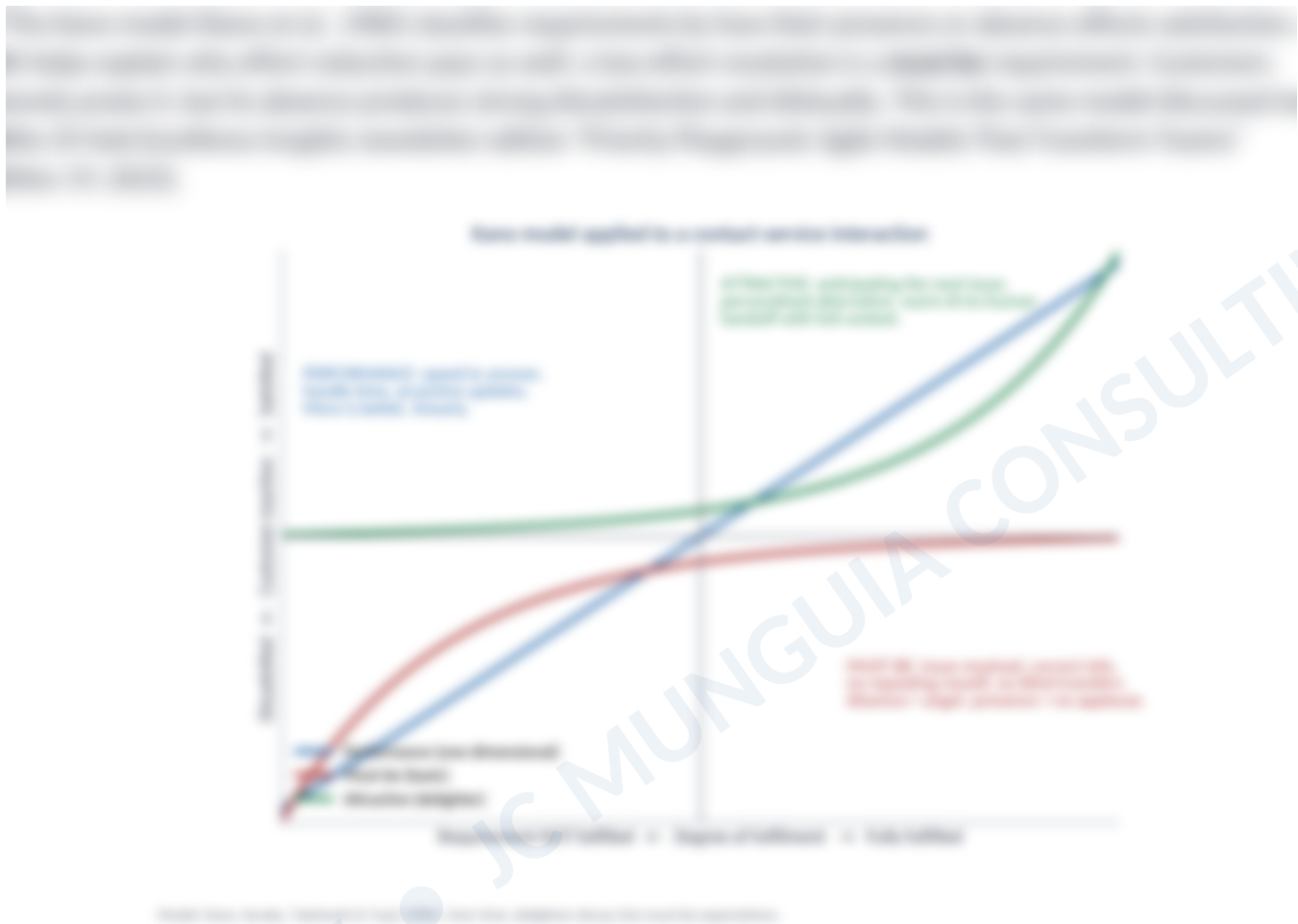
Part	Skills	What it does
What I hear	Listening skills	Helps you understand what the customer is saying and what they need.
How I respond	Communication skills	Helps you communicate effectively with the customer.
Develop self-awareness	Self-awareness	Helps you understand your own strengths and weaknesses.
Maintain self-awareness	Self-awareness	Helps you stay focused on the customer's needs.

1.9 How does this benefit me?

Day-to-day benefit	What changes
Improved customer service	Helps you understand what the customer is saying and what they need.
Increased sales	Helps you communicate effectively with the customer.
Reduced customer complaints	Helps you understand your own strengths and weaknesses.
Improved customer loyalty	Helps you stay focused on the customer's needs.

Scorecard metric	Expected effect
Customer satisfaction	Helps you understand what the customer is saying and what they need.
Customer retention	Helps you communicate effectively with the customer.
Customer loyalty	Helps you understand your own strengths and weaknesses.
Customer engagement	Helps you stay focused on the customer's needs.

1.10 Where effort sits in the Kano model



Kano category	Contact-center examples	What to do
Must-be (basic)	Basic service requirements, such as fast response times, accurate information, and polite agents.	Ensure these requirements are met consistently, as they are the foundation for customer satisfaction.
Performance	Service quality, such as the accuracy of information, the speed of service, and the quality of the agent's interaction.	Continuously improve these areas to drive higher satisfaction levels.
Attractive (delighter)	Surprise and delight factors, such as personalized service, proactive problem-solving, and going above and beyond for the customer.	Identify and implement these factors to create memorable customer experiences.
Indifferent	Factors that do not significantly impact satisfaction, such as the color of the agent's uniform or the background music.	Focus resources on areas that directly impact satisfaction.
Reverse	Factors that can cause dissatisfaction, such as long wait times, inconsistent service, or poor agent behavior.	Identify and eliminate these factors to prevent dissatisfaction.

Module 1 review

1. What is the main purpose of the Customer Experience Engineering process?

2. What are the key components of the Customer Experience Engineering process?

3. How does the Customer Experience Engineering process help in improving customer satisfaction?

4. What are the benefits of the Customer Experience Engineering process?

5. How can the Customer Experience Engineering process be implemented in an organization?

6. What are the challenges of the Customer Experience Engineering process?

7. How can the challenges of the Customer Experience Engineering process be overcome?

8. What are the key success factors for the Customer Experience Engineering process?

9. How can the Customer Experience Engineering process be used to improve the overall business performance?

10. What are the future trends of the Customer Experience Engineering process?

2

What I Hear

Skill 1 Active Listening and Skill 2 Purposeful Small Talk: getting the right information

Want the full content?

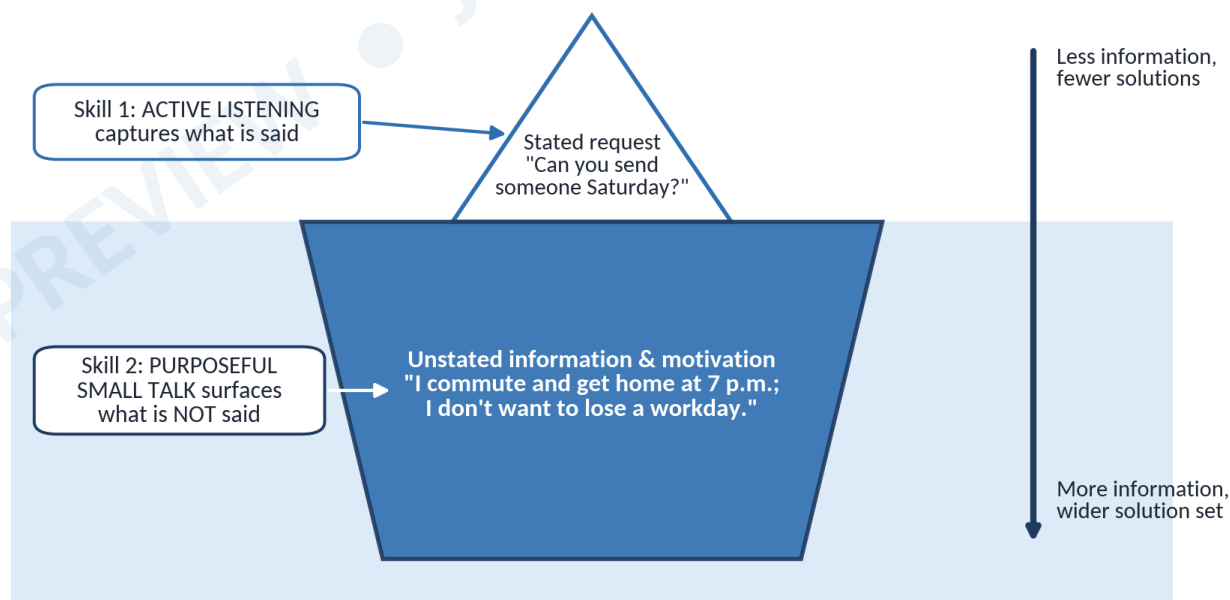
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Goal of this part of the framework

Collect all the information you need from the customer to offer the best possible solution. **Active listening** uses what the customer volunteers. **Purposeful small talk** uncovers the key information they did not volunteer.



Skill 1: Active listening

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify the components of active listening
- Use active listening in customer cases and daily interactions, including chat and email (active reading)

Four qualities of active listeners

ATTENTION	OBJECTIVITY	PATIENCE	EMPATHY
Stay engaged and focused on what the customer is saying.			

Keeping your attention: four moves

Move	Confirm	Clarify	Paraphrase	Summarize
Examples				
Purpose				
Chat / email version				

Warning signs that you are NOT listening actively

1. You are thinking about what you are going to say next while the other person is speaking.
2. You are interrupting the other person.
3. You are not making eye contact with the other person.
4. You are not nodding or giving feedback to the other person.
5. You are not asking questions to clarify what the other person is saying.

ACTIVITY Four qualities and low effort

1. The first quality is to be present. When you are present, you are fully engaged in the conversation and you are not distracted by your thoughts or by the environment.
2. The second quality is to be curious. When you are curious, you are interested in what the other person is saying and you want to learn more about them.
3. The third quality is to be empathetic. When you are empathetic, you are able to understand the other person's feelings and perspective.
4. The fourth quality is to be non-judgmental. When you are non-judgmental, you are able to listen to the other person without making any assumptions or judgments about them.

ACTIVITY Practicing active listening (pairs)

1. The first step is to choose a partner. You will be working in pairs for this activity.
2. The second step is to take turns. One person will speak and the other person will listen. After a few minutes, they will switch roles.
3. The third step is to use the four qualities. While listening, the listener should be present, curious, empathetic, and non-judgmental.
4. The fourth step is to give feedback. After each person has spoken, the listener should give feedback on how well they listened and how they felt.

Skill 2: Purposeful small talk

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain what purposeful small talk is and how it helps you
- Recognize opportunities for small talk and ask questions at the right level

Asking questions at the right level



Open- vs. closed-ended questions

Open-ended questions	Closed-ended questions
What time is it? What time is it? What time is it?	What time is it? What time is it? What time is it?

What it looks like in action (ACME Telecom)

Speaker	Words	Agent's objective
Agent (Luis)	Good morning, my name is Luis. How can I help you today?	Identify the customer's needs and provide a solution.
Customer	Hi, I'm having trouble with my internet connection. It's very slow.	Understand the problem and offer assistance.
Agent (Luis)	I'm sorry to hear that. Let me check your account and see what's going on.	Investigate the issue and provide a solution.
Customer	Thank you. I appreciate your help.	Ensure the customer is satisfied and provide feedback.

ACTIVITY Asking questions to uncover customer information

1. What is the customer's name? 2. What is the customer's email address? 3. What is the customer's phone number? 4. What is the customer's account number? 5. What is the customer's address? 6. What is the customer's date of birth? 7. What is the customer's gender? 8. What is the customer's marital status? 9. What is the customer's occupation? 10. What is the customer's education level?	1. What is the customer's name? 2. What is the customer's email address? 3. What is the customer's phone number? 4. What is the customer's account number? 5. What is the customer's address? 6. What is the customer's date of birth? 7. What is the customer's gender? 8. What is the customer's marital status? 9. What is the customer's occupation? 10. What is the customer's education level?
--	--

Scenario	My question(s)	Information I could uncover
Scenario 1: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 2: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 3: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 4: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 5: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 6: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		
Scenario 7: A customer is experiencing a problem with their account and is unable to access their data.		

3

How I Respond

Skill 3 Positive Language, Skill 4 Advocacy, Skill 5 Alternative Positioning: guiding the conversation

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Goal of this part of the framework

Guide the conversation to present solutions in the best possible light.

Positive language: choose your words carefully to minimize customer effort.

Advocacy: champion the customer's issue and own its resolution.

Alternative positioning: match the customer's needs and motivations with the solutions available.

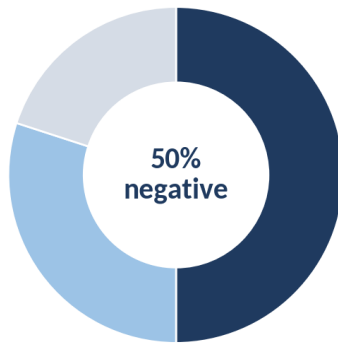
Skill 3: Positive language

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Tell positive from negative language and describe the effect of each on the experience
- Recognize and avoid common words and phrases that create customer effort

It's not just you, it's everyone

Emotion words in everyday vocabulary



■ Negative 50% ■ Positive 30% ■ Neutral 20%

Words that silently raise effort

require
can't
policy
not my department
no
shouldn't
won't
they
have to
you need to
unfortunately

What negative language leads to

Effect	Evidence

Small changes, big effects

Rep response A: negative language	Rep response B: positive language



Updated evidence: what newer research adds

Research shows that students who are highly motivated and engaged in their studies are more likely to succeed. This is because they are more likely to be active learners, seeking out challenges and opportunities for growth. They are also more likely to be resilient in the face of setbacks and to seek out support when needed. This research suggests that educators should focus on creating a supportive learning environment that encourages student engagement and motivation. This can be done by providing students with a variety of learning experiences, including both traditional classroom instruction and more experiential learning opportunities. Educators should also provide students with regular feedback and encouragement, and should be available to provide support when needed. By creating a supportive learning environment, educators can help students to become more motivated and engaged learners, and thus more likely to succeed in their studies.

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Skill 5: Alternative positioning

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Use the information gathered during the conversation to position tailored solutions when the first option is not available



How to position your company's solutions in the market

Principle	How
Identify the customer's needs and the company's capabilities.	Use the information gathered during the conversation to position tailored solutions when the first option is not available.
Identify the customer's needs and the company's capabilities.	Use the information gathered during the conversation to position tailored solutions when the first option is not available.
Identify the customer's needs and the company's capabilities.	Use the information gathered during the conversation to position tailored solutions when the first option is not available.

Decision tree: small talk and alternative positioning



Use small talk with customers who are...

Avoid it with customers who are...

What do you do when "no" is the only answer?

DO

DON'T

Revisiting the conversation: all five skills together

Speaker	Words	Skill in use
Customer	Hi, I'm having trouble with my account. I can't log in.	Identify the problem
Agent (Luis)	Hi, I'm sorry to hear that. Let me help you. Can you tell me what error message you're seeing?	Identify the problem, Acknowledge the problem, Offer help
Customer	It says "Invalid password". I've tried several times.	Identify the problem
Agent (Luis)	Okay, let's reset your password. I'll send you a link to your email. Please check your inbox.	Offer help, Provide instructions

ACTIVITY Role plays: responding with positive language

Scenario	Instructions
1. A customer is complaining about a delayed delivery.	Practice responding with empathy and offering a solution.
2. A customer is asking for a refund.	Practice responding with understanding and explaining the refund process.
3. A customer is asking for a discount.	Practice responding with politeness and explaining the company's pricing policy.
4. A customer is asking for a replacement.	Practice responding with willingness to help and explaining the replacement process.
5. A customer is asking for a warranty.	Practice responding with confidence and explaining the warranty details.
6. A customer is asking for a recommendation.	Practice responding with helpful suggestions and product knowledge.
7. A customer is asking for a testimonial.	Practice responding with enthusiasm and sharing positive feedback.
8. A customer is asking for a referral.	Practice responding with professionalism and providing contact information.
9. A customer is asking for a consultation.	Practice responding with expertise and offering a free trial.
10. A customer is asking for a partnership.	Practice responding with interest and discussing collaboration opportunities.

4

Develop and Maintain Self-Awareness

Skill 6 Understanding My Dominant Personality Style and Skill 7 Flexing to Others' Personalities

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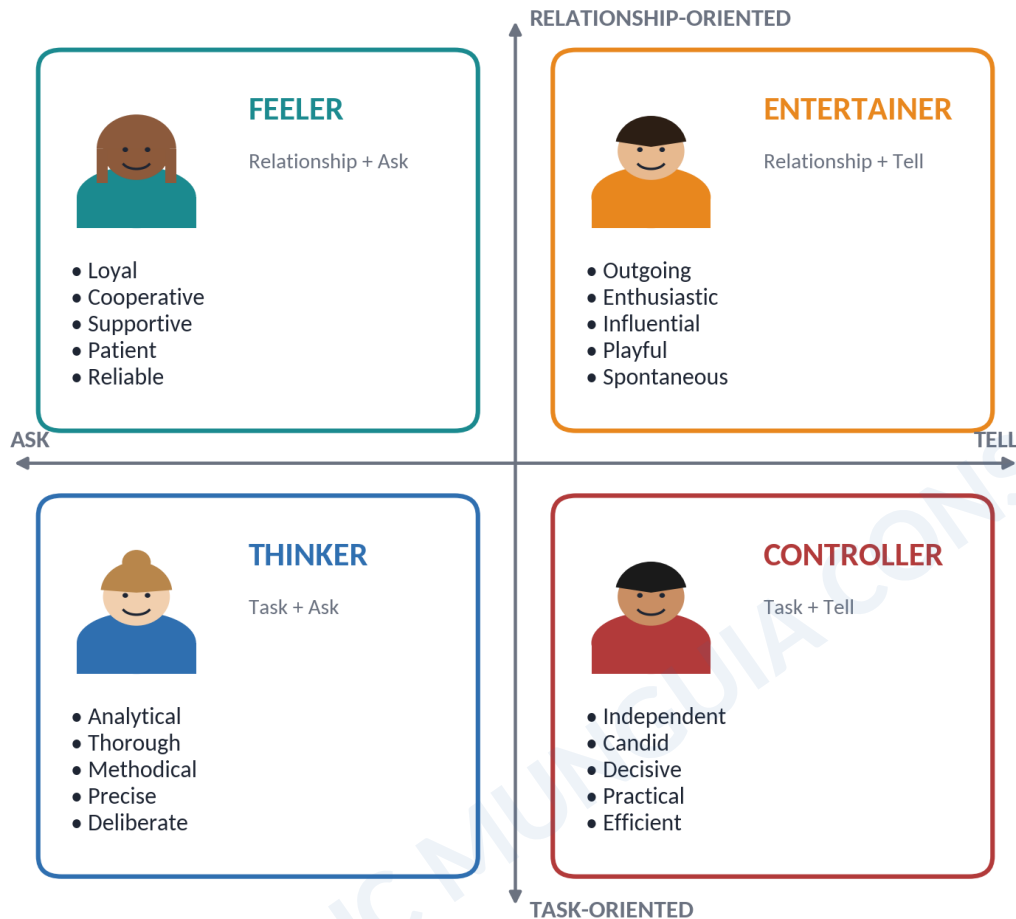
Goal of this part of the framework

Keep control of your own actions in stressful situations without burning out. To manage customer interactions, you first have to manage yourself. Knowing your style is the foundation that lets you keep listening, making purposeful small talk, using positive language, advocating and positioning solutions, even under stress.

Skill 6: Understanding my dominant personality style

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify your personality style and how it is uniquely suited to serving customers
- Recognize your style's stress response and choose ways to cope with and manage stress



Customer service by personality style

Style	Strengths	Keep in mind
Feeler		
Entertainer		
Thinker		
Controller		

ACTIVITY How my style fits experience engineering		
1. Active listening 2. Purposeful small talk 3. Positive language 4. Advocacy 5. Positioning solutions		
Skill	My rating (1-5)	One thing I will do to strengthen it
1 Active listening		
2 Purposeful small talk		
3 Positive language		
4 Advocacy		
5 Positioning solutions		

How each style reacts to stress



Style	Stress response	Early warning signs (write your own)	Recovery tactic
Feeler	Stress response: Feels stress, reacts emotionally, seeks support from others.	Early warning signs: (write your own)	Recovery tactic: (write your own)
Entertainer	Stress response: Feels stress, reacts with humor, seeks attention and fun.	Early warning signs: (write your own)	Recovery tactic: (write your own)
Thinker	Stress response: Feels stress, reacts logically, seeks information and analysis.	Early warning signs: (write your own)	Recovery tactic: (write your own)
Controller	Stress response: Feels stress, reacts with anger, seeks control and order.	Early warning signs: (write your own)	Recovery tactic: (write your own)

Skill 7: Flexing to others' personalities

By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Identify your customers' personality styles
- Adapt your approach to interact effectively with each style



Style	They sound like	Traits	Remember to
Feeler (empathy-oriented)	They are very empathetic and care about others' feelings.	They are very empathetic and care about others' feelings.	They are very empathetic and care about others' feelings.
Entertainer (social-oriented)	They are very social and enjoy being the center of attention.	They are very social and enjoy being the center of attention.	They are very social and enjoy being the center of attention.
Thinker (process-oriented)	They are very logical and enjoy solving problems.	They are very logical and enjoy solving problems.	They are very logical and enjoy solving problems.
Controller (results-oriented)	They are very results-oriented and want to get things done.	They are very results-oriented and want to get things done.	They are very results-oriented and want to get things done.

Flexing guide: if you are... and they are...

You are ↓ / They are →	Controller	Thinker	Entertainer	Feeler
Controller				
Thinker				
Entertainer				
Feeler				

ACTIVITY

Role plays: personality-based communication

1. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
2. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
3. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
4. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
5. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
6. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.
7. The participant will be assigned a role and a personality type. The participant will be given a scenario and a list of questions to ask the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer. The participant will be given 5 minutes to prepare and then will be asked to role play the scenario with the customer.

5

Experience Engineering in the AI Era

Applying the seven skills in hybrid (AI + human) journeys and digital channels

Want the full content?

This **free preview** shows the structure and about 30% of the Customer Experience Engineering Participant Manual. The full program includes every skill, tool, script, updated 2024-2026 data, the leader track, and four certification assessments (theory + role plays + live interactions).

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By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Explain how AI and self-service change what reaches the human agent
- Handle a customer who arrives after a failed bot or self-service attempt without adding effort
- Apply the seven skills in chat, email and messaging, and when using AI agent-assist tools

5.1 What the 2025-2026 data says

Finding	What it means for you	Source (date)
Customers want to interact with AI, but only if it's transparent and can be easily escalated to a human agent.	AI should be used as a first line of support, but with clear paths for escalation to human agents when needed.	McKinsey & Company (2025)
Transparency is key: customers value knowing when they are interacting with AI and being able to reach a human agent.	Design AI interactions to be transparent about their capabilities and limitations, and provide easy access to human support.	Accenture (2025)
AI should handle routine tasks, while human agents focus on complex, high-touch issues.	Implement a hybrid model where AI handles standard queries and human agents step in for more complex or emotional situations.	Deloitte (2025)
Warm handoffs from AI to human agents significantly improve customer satisfaction.	Ensure a smooth transition of context when a customer is handed off from AI to a human agent.	Capgemini (2025)
Agents should acknowledge the AI attempt and reassure the customer that their information is being passed on.	Train human agents to provide a seamless continuation of the service initiated by the AI.	IBM (2025)
Self-service options should be available, but with the option to get help at any point.	Design self-service journeys that are intuitive and include clear exit points for assistance.	Capgemini (2025)

Engineering the hybrid (AI + human) journey



Agent opening after a failed bot: "I can see you already tried the assistant and gave us your account and the error code. I've got it here, so you won't need to repeat anything."

5.2 The seven skills after a failed bot

Skill	What to do in the first 60 seconds
1. Acknowledge the failure	Apologize and let the customer know the bot failed to assist them.
2. Understand the issue	Ask the customer to explain the problem in their own words.
3. Offer a solution	Provide a clear, concise solution to the problem.
4. Confirm understanding	Ask the customer if they understand the solution and if they need further assistance.
5. Follow up	Check back with the customer to ensure the problem is resolved.
6. Thank the customer	Express appreciation for the customer's patience and understanding.
7. Learn from the experience	Use the feedback to improve the bot's performance.

5.3 Digital-channel adaptations

Channel	Do	Avoid
Chat / messaging	Use emojis to convey tone and emotion.	Use too many emojis or slang.
Email	Use a professional and concise tone.	Use a casual or overly formal tone.
Agent-assist / GenAI drafts	Use AI to generate drafts and suggestions.	Use AI to generate final responses.
Social / public	Respond quickly and publicly.	Respond slowly or privately.
Watch out: critical errors in the AI era Avoid using AI-generated content that is inaccurate, biased, or offensive. Always review and edit AI-generated content before publishing it.		

6

Leading by Example (Leader Track)

Your customers are your agents: using the same standard to build a low-effort culture

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By the end of this section you will be able to:

- Apply the seven skills with agents, who are the leader's internal customers
- Run COPC R8.0-aligned monitoring, coaching and calibration that reinforce experience engineering
- Measure and reduce both customer effort and agent (CSS) effort
- Lead team rituals that make low effort the way the team works

6.1 The parallel process

The parallel process: how leaders treat agents is how agents treat customers



Employee effort (CSS effort) is an explicit input in COPC CX Standard R8.0, Item 3.9 (Optimizing Service Journeys).

Updated evidence (2026)

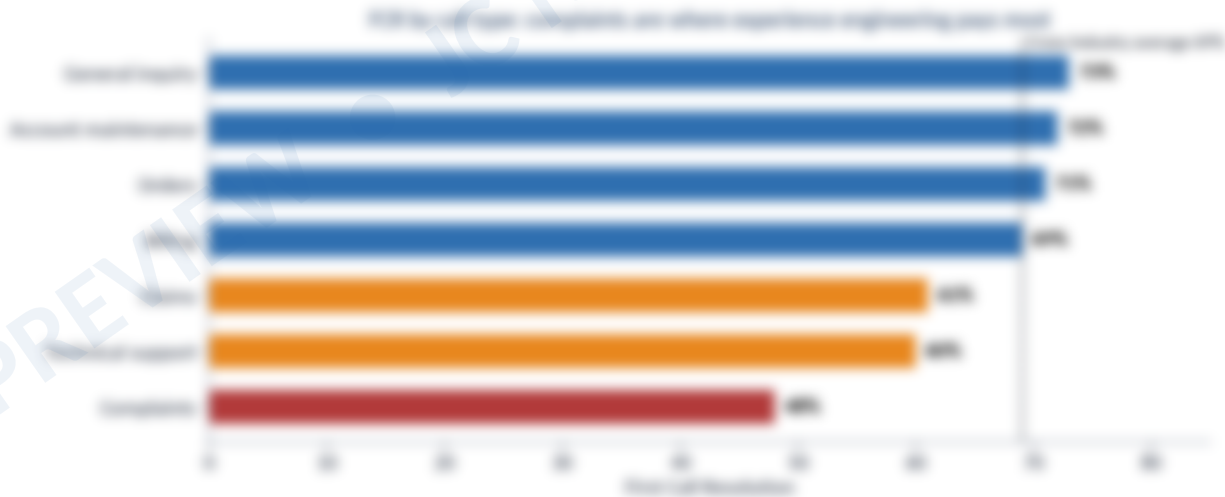
6.4 Monitoring, calibration and coaching aligned with COPC R8.0

Figure 6.4.1: Monitoring, calibration and coaching aligned with COPC R8.0



6.5 Measuring effort: the leader's dashboard

Metric	Definition	Why it matters	Typical direction
Customer Effort Score (CES)	How easy it is for customers to get their problem solved	Lower scores indicate less effort, which is better	Down
First Contact Resolution (FCR)	Percentage of issues resolved on the first contact	Higher percentages indicate better service	Up
Repeat contact rate (7 days)	Percentage of customers who contact again within 7 days	Lower percentages indicate better service	Down
Transfer rate	Percentage of calls transferred to another agent	Lower percentages indicate better service	Down
CSAT top box and DSAT	Customer Satisfaction (top box) and Dissatisfaction (bottom box)	Higher top box and lower bottom box indicate better service	Up (top box), Down (bottom box)
Customer critical error accuracy	Percentage of critical errors correctly identified	Higher percentages indicate better service	Up
Agent effort / eNPS	Employee Net Promoter Score	Higher scores indicate better service	Up



Worked example: calculating CES and the value of FCR

The Customer Effort Score (CES) is a measure of how easy it is for customers to get their problem solved. It is calculated using the following formula:

$$CES = \frac{1}{1 + \frac{FCR}{100}}$$

Where FCR is the First Contact Resolution percentage.

For example, if the FCR is 90%, the CES would be:

$$CES = \frac{1}{1 + \frac{90}{100}} = \frac{1}{1.9} \approx 0.526$$

The value of FCR is a measure of the percentage of issues resolved on the first contact. It is calculated using the following formula:

$$FCR = \frac{\text{Number of issues resolved on first contact}}{\text{Total number of issues}} \times 100$$

For example, if 90 out of 100 issues were resolved on the first contact, the FCR would be 90%.

6.6 Building the culture: team rituals

Ritual	Frequency	How it works
Effort huddle	10-15 mins	At the start of each day, team members share their top priority for the day and how they plan to achieve it. This helps everyone understand each other's work and provides a chance for support and encouragement.
Effort hunt	10-15 mins	At the end of each day, team members share their top achievement and how they achieved it. This helps everyone celebrate success and learn from each other's experiences.
Golden calls	10-15 mins	At the end of each day, team members share their top call or interaction with a customer. This helps everyone understand each other's work and provides a chance for support and encouragement.
Leader self-check	10-15 mins	At the end of each day, the leader shares their top achievement and how they achieved it. This helps everyone celebrate success and learn from the leader's experiences.
Kano backlog	10-15 mins	At the end of each day, team members share their top call or interaction with a customer. This helps everyone understand each other's work and provides a chance for support and encouragement.

Watch out: leader behaviors that destroy the culture

Leaders should avoid behaviors that can destroy the culture, such as being inconsistent, not following through on promises, or not being transparent. Leaders should also avoid behaviors that can create a negative culture, such as being overly critical or not recognizing team members' achievements.

ACTIVITY	Leader practice: flip the scenario
Scenario 1: A team member is struggling with a task. The leader intervenes and provides support. The team member is grateful and the task is completed successfully. Scenario 2: A team member is struggling with a task. The leader intervenes and provides support. The team member is grateful and the task is completed successfully. Scenario 3: A team member is struggling with a task. The leader intervenes and provides support. The team member is grateful and the task is completed successfully. Scenario 4: A team member is struggling with a task. The leader intervenes and provides support. The team member is grateful and the task is completed successfully.	

Topic Facilitation, Summary and Next Steps

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ACTIVITY	Topic facilitation (team practice)
1. Introduction to the topic	Topic facilitator introduces the topic and its relevance to the course.
2. Presentation of the topic	Topic facilitator presents the topic and its key concepts.
3. Group discussion	Students are divided into groups to discuss the topic and its key concepts.
4. Group presentation	Each group presents their discussion findings to the class.
5. Summary and conclusion	Topic facilitator summarizes the key points and concludes the session.

Situation	Avoid	Say instead
Opening after a failed bot	"I'm sorry, I can't help you with that."	"I can't help you with that, but I can help you with..."
Can't do it now	"I can't do that for you."	"I can't do that for you right now, but I can help you with..."
Out of stock	"We're out of stock of that item."	"That item is currently out of stock, but we have..."
Transfer	"I'm going to transfer you to..."	"I'll connect you with..."
Policy	"Our policy is..."	"Our policy is... but I can help you with..."
Customer error	"You made a mistake..."	"It seems like there might be a misunderstanding..."
Waiting	"Wait..."	"I'll be right with you..."
Uncertain outcome	"I'm not sure..."	"I'll do my best to help you..."
Complaint	"I'm sorry..."	"I understand your frustration..."
Closing	"Thank you..."	"I hope I've been helpful..."
Leader to agent: feedback	"You did that wrong..."	"I noticed a small error, but overall you did well..."
Leader to agent: can't grant a request	"I can't do that for you..."	"I understand your request, but I'm not able to grant it..."

Appendix C. Glossary

Appendix D. Program documents and key references

Code	Document
001	Customer Experience Strategy
002	Customer Experience Design
003	Customer Experience Measurement
004	Customer Experience Improvement
005	Customer Experience Implementation
006	Customer Experience Evaluation
007	Customer Experience Optimization
008	Customer Experience Innovation
009	Customer Experience Transformation
010	Customer Experience Future

Customer Experience Engineering is a discipline that focuses on the design and implementation of customer experiences. It involves understanding the customer journey, identifying pain points, and creating a seamless and personalized experience for the customer. This discipline is essential for businesses to stay competitive in today's market, as customers expect high-quality experiences from all brands.

Get the full certification program

You have seen the map. The full edition gives your team the whole journey:

- The complete 49-page Participant Manual: seven skills, AI-era journeys, and the Leader Track (leading by example)
- Assessment A and B: theoretical exams for agents and leaders
- Assessment C and D: practical certification with role plays and live interactions, COPC R8.0-aligned scorecards
- Facilitator Guide with answer keys, actor briefs and evaluator calibration
- Evidence and Sources Pack with 2024-2026 data and verification links
- Implementation support: tailoring to your operation, train-the-trainer, and measurement of effort (CES, FCR, repeat contacts)

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